So this is what a once-free society has been reduced to: multiple police squads, each consisting of a sub-inspector and two constables, patrolling Uttar Pradesh's university campuses, college yards, cinema theatres, parks and other public places, looking for "Romeos". The term seems to be loosely defined, entitling the cops to stop and question any young couple. While it may have once been intended to curb harassment by louts loafing in public places to "eve-tease" unwary women, the sheer numbers reported confirm that the harassment is now coming mainly from the authorities and not from their targets.

The term "anti-Romeo squad" is itself telling. It traces its origins to the "Roadside Romeos" of my own youth—raffish fellows in drainpipe pants, wavy locks and rakish moustaches, usually unemployed, who lounged about whistling at, or singing snatches of Bollywood film songs to, passing women. They were usually ignored, and mostly harmless. Today's UP police have a far broader target: a Romeo is any young man aspiring to woo his own Juliet. Shakespeare's Romeo, after all, defied convention and evaded his disapproving parents to pursue his love for a woman from the wrong family. That is precisely what Yogi Adityanath does not want Romeo's 21st century imitators to do.

The anti-Romeo squads are merely the latest sign of the continuing assault on any cultural practice deemed to be insufficiently Hindu by the self-appointed guardians of Indian culture. A new spurt of arrests is likely as the anti-Romeo squads double their vigilance for Valentine's Day. Until Yogi's victory, policing Valentine's Day lovers was a task undertaken by lumpen activists of assorted *senas* and *dals*; now, in a sort of reverse privatisation, it is a task that has been taken up by the BJP-run state.

And what of the freelance anti-romance troublemakers? After years of attacking couples holding hands on 14 February, trashing stores selling Valentine's Day greeting cards and shouting slogans outside cafes with canoodling couples, Hindutva activists changed tactics last year. The Hindu Mahasabha announced that it would send squads out to catch any unmarried couples out for a tryst on Valentine's Day and promptly cart them off to a temple to be married. (And, if the Hindutvavadi MP and Godse admirer Sakshi Maharaj has his way, they will be lectured on the